

Poems from a Black Boy

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Introductory Note

This is not just a book; it's an invitation. It's an opportunity to step into the quiet corners of my thoughts, where restless whispers come alive in the stillness of night. Here, you'll find love and pain, sacrifice and longing, the weight of truth, and the ache of absence.

This is a glimpse into the inner workings of my mind a mind shaped by a world that speaks to me but rarely listens, that sees us but rarely sees us. Let this book be the beginning of something deeper: a journey where you don't just read, but feel. Where you don't just listen, but hear.

These pages are a tease, a taste of the Black boy's mind a place where silence holds power and vulnerability becomes strength. This is the prologue to a story still unfolding. A story of lies, of breaking and becoming, of finding beauty in the truth and power in the quiet.

It's the first step, the first breath, the first heartbeat of a journey that will leave you yearning for more. So, turn the page. Let these words pull you in. And when you reach the end, know this: it's only the beginning.

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Identity and Resilience

Introduction:

This section explores the journey of self-discovery and the strength required to maintain one's identity in a world that often misunderstands or misrepresents. These poems speak to the weight of history, the quiet power of authenticity, and the courage to become who you truly are despite external pressures. Here, vulnerability becomes strength, and the process of unbecoming what others expect reveals the true self beneath.

THE BLACK BOY LIE

I was born beneath bruised skies, a child of fire and shadow,
My skin, a prophecy the world had already rewritten.
Before I could speak, the lie was whispered in my ear
You are danger before you are a dream.

I learned to walk the tightrope between threat and survival,
To smile when I wanted to scream, to fight when I longed to be held.
My hands, too rough to cradle innocence, too soft to bear the weight of expectation.
They made me a weapon, then feared the sharpness of my edges.

I carry names in my blood those spoken, those stolen,
Each syllable a prayer, each silence a grave.
They tell me to move on, to forget the weight of history,
But how do you forget the chains when they are stitched into your skin?

They said I was born to run, but never to escape.
Said my anger was a wildfire, never warmth against the cold.
Taught me to be a warrior but never a child,
A body before a soul, a shadow before a man.

I have watched my brothers become martyrs, their stories rewritten in ink that bleeds,
The world mourning them with the same hands that once trembled in their presence.
I have seen my reflection splinter in the weight of their expectations,
Told I am too much, too little, too lost, too alive.

But I am the ghost that refuses to be buried,
The hymn that rises through clenched teeth,
The prophecy they tried to silence, the fire they could not tame.

I am more than what they fear, more than what they praise.
I am the storm and the stillness after.
I am the truth they never speak.
I am the Black boy they tried to break
And I am still here.

The Weight of Knowing

I woke up with the sun
and felt its light dance inside me,
but the weight of knowing was already there.
It clung to my skin like the shadow of old paths,
from places I've passed but never truly escaped.

There is a heaviness in the air I breathe,
a reminder that the world doesn't always wait
for me to catch up to its pace.
In my bones, I carry stories
some mine, others borrowed
whispered too loud to ignore.

I've been taught to let them simmer
beneath my skin until they burn like fire.
Sometimes, I wish to forget,
to be free from the burden of memory.
But even in silence, it speaks.

Is it enough to carry the past with grace?
Can I stand tall in a world that wants me to shrink?
Or must I fight against the weight,
the gravity of all that I know?

I've learned that freedom isn't the absence of it
it's the willingness to stand under the weight,
to let it shape me into someone
stronger than what I was before.

And so, I breathe in deep,
and I carry it all forward.

Reflection

This poem speaks to the tension between knowing too much and still living fully. The weight of the past feels like a shadow, always present but invisible to others. While I sometimes yearn for release, I've learned that carrying this weight is not a burden it's a testament to my strength. It's about finding peace in the knowledge that I am shaped by everything I've lived and survived.

The Forty Days

I have wandered this desert for forty days,
Each step leaving imprints that the wind erases,
As if my journey was never meant to be remembered.
The sun burns away my certainties,
Leaving only the raw truth of who I am.

I came here full
Full of pride, full of answers,
Full of the noise that drowned out my own voice.
Now I am emptied,
Hollowed out by hunger and thirst,
By questions that echo in the vastness.

They told me this was punishment,
But I have found revelation in the barren places,
In the silence that speaks louder than any sermon.
The temptations come at night
To turn stone to bread, to leap from heights,
To worship the false gods of comfort and certainty.

But I remain,
Stripped to bone and spirit,
Finding strength in my emptiness.
For it is only when we are broken open
That the light can finally enter.

I will return from this wilderness
Not as I came, but transformed
A man who has faced his demons
And learned they were only shadows,
Cast by a light I could not yet see.

Reflection:

This poem mirrors the biblical story of Jesus' 40 days in the wilderness, but it also speaks to the universal human experience of transformation through struggle. The desert becomes a metaphor for the internal battles we face when stripped of distractions. It fits perfectly in *Identity and Resilience* because it explores the strength found in vulnerability and the courage to confront oneself.

The Quiet Strength

I don't need to scream to be heard.
I have learned the art of standing still,
of letting silence wrap around me like armor.
There's power in silence
not in its emptiness, but in its fullness.
In the space between words, I become my own voice.

I am not the loudest in the room,
but I have learned that the loudest voices
are often afraid to hear their own truth.
I know this because I've been there
drowning out my own voice,
afraid to let it break the air.
But now, I stand firm,
quietly claiming the space I deserve.

My strength doesn't need to be seen;
it pulses beneath the surface,
like a river carving its path through stone.
It's in the way I carry my head,
in the way I don't bow to expectations,
in the way I refuse to be anything but what I am.
I am not the loudest,
but I am steady
and that, too, is a form of strength.

Reflection

This poem reminds me that strength doesn't have to be loud. I used to think power meant being seen and heard, but I've learned that quiet confidence and persistence are just as powerful. True strength lies in knowing who you are and refusing to let the world define you.

Unbecoming

I used to believe I could be everything to everyone
a chameleon changing to fit their needs,
always bending, never breaking.
But what happens when you bend too long,
when the shape you take no longer fits your soul?
I learned the hard way that
unbecoming isn't weakness;
it's the beginning of finding the truth beneath the layers.

I had to break the mold
not because I didn't love those who shaped it,
but because I realized I couldn't survive in a form
that wasn't mine.
And so, I unraveled,
piece by piece,
like a book with pages torn but still readable,
still worthy of being understood.

There's freedom in unbecoming
in shedding the expectations,
the labels that never suited me,
the roles I was told I should play.
In the space left behind,
I find myself again
more raw, more real,
and more in love with who I am
outside the shadow of who I thought I had to be.

And in that freedom, I rise.

Reflection

This poem reflects a time when I felt trapped by others' expectations. Unbecoming was painful, but it was also liberating. I've learned that shedding the layers of who we think we should be is the only way to discover who we truly are.

The Rhythm of Rage and Grace

I walk a path paved with contradictions anger intertwined with longing,
A dance of fury and fragile beauty in every step I dare to take,
In the depths of my rage, I find echoes of a sorrow unspoken,
A beat that pounds the rhythm of my defiant, conflicted soul.

In moments of explosive wrath, I become both destroyer and creation,
Firing back at a world that labels my pain as inherent sin,
Yet beneath the searing heat of vengeance lies a tender yearning,
For love, for understanding, for the freedom to simply be me.

Every clenched fist is a story, every slammed door a secret lament,
The weight of centuries borne in a single, burning glance,
I oscillate between the roles of aggressor and wounded survivor,
A symphony of contradictions where rage and grace collide.

The world demands that I choose one path either the storm or the calm,
But within me, both chaos and calm coexist in a delicate balance,
In the fury of my outburst, I also find the seeds of tender hope,
A reminder that even in the darkest nights, a soft light can emerge.

I scrawl my defiance on the walls of every forgotten alley,
Each word a burst of raw emotion, a testament to battles fought,
My heart beats a relentless cadence of resilience and desire,
Pulsing with the rhythm of a life that refuses to be defined by hate.

At times, my voice is a thunderous roar that drowns out every doubt,
At others, it is a quiet murmur filled with the promise of healing,
I navigate the storm within, a journey of relentless contradiction,
Where every cry of rage is softened by a whisper of grace.

In the interplay of fury and tenderness, I glimpse my true self,
A boy molded by a world that demanded both surrender and fight,
I embrace the complexity of my being, the light within the dark,
Knowing that every moment of anger is tempered by unyielding love.

I watch the tears that follow the blaze of my unleashed fury,
And in their glistening trails, I see a reflection of hidden hope,
A truth that no amount of rage can erase or diminish completely,
For even in pain, there is a beauty that whispers of redemption.

As I stand at the crossroads of my emotions, raw and unrefined,
I surrender to the pulse that drives my ever-contradictory heart,
Acknowledging that my rage and grace are two sides of the same coin,
And this is the black boy lie.

The Mirror

He stood in front of it every morning,
facing a reflection that didn't feel like his own.
He looked into the eyes staring back at him,
but saw someone else
someone he didn't recognize.
It wasn't that he didn't know the face,
but that he had never learned to trust it.

The mirror was his enemy,
its truth sharper than any insult,
its judgment colder than anything
he had ever felt.
He saw all the things he was taught to hide
the shame, the fear, the anger,
the things he was never allowed to feel
because to feel them was to admit
that something was wrong.

But every day, he faced it.
And each day, he grew a little braver,
a little closer to seeing himself
without the distortion of what he was told to be.
And one day, he'd look in that mirror
and finally say,
"I'm enough, just as I am."

Reflection:

The mirror is always an honest reflection of who we are, even when we refuse to see it. So many of us grow up learning to hate the things we see in ourselves the parts that were too raw, too real to show. But there's a quiet strength in learning to face that reflection, to accept everything we've been told is wrong with us. I've seen friends struggle with self image, with the lies they were taught about their worth. It's a painful journey to start trusting the reflection, to realize that you are enough even when the world doesn't see you as such. But the day you finally accept it that's the day the mirror can no longer be your enemy.

The Inner War

Every day is a battle between
What you feel you should do,
And what your soul begs you to do.
The fear of failure and the shame of success
Dance like shadows on your path,
Twisting and turning in the light of your ambition.

What if the war isn't out there,
But within?
What if the enemy is not the world,
But the stories you tell yourself
About who you are and what you can become?

Peace begins with the quiet voice
That reminds you of your power,
The voice that refuses to be silenced,
Even in the face of your greatest doubts.

Reflection: I realize that the battles I fight aren't always external. The real war is in my mind. It's the narratives I've believed, the ones that tell me I'm not enough or I don't belong. I've begun to learn that peace doesn't come from winning the fight outside; it starts from quieting the war inside.

The Beauty of Becoming

You are not a finished piece,
Not yet.
You are a collection of moments,
Each one teaching you how to rise.
Each day, you choose again
What to shed, what to carry.
What to honor, what to release.

The beauty of becoming
Is in the unknown,
In the messy,
In the unrefined pieces
That don't yet have a name.
You are still becoming,
And that is the miracle.

Trust in the unfolding,
In the space between your dreams
And the steps you take toward them.
You do not have to have it all figured out.
All you need is the courage to keep moving.

Reflection: I'm learning that I'm not supposed to have it all figured out right now. Becoming isn't about a destination it's about the journey, the unpolished parts of myself that still hold so much beauty. There's power in the unfolding, in the courage to move forward without a clear map.

Love and Vulnerability

Introduction:

In this collection of poems, love is explored not as an idealized fantasy but as a courageous act of showing up authentically. These verses delve into the spaces between people the unspoken connections, the quiet understanding, and the bravery required to remain open despite the risk of pain. Here, love is portrayed as both a choice and a journey, requiring strength, compassion, and the willingness to be seen in all your complexity.

The Courage to Love

Love is not always easy,
Not the way we want it to be.
It is not the perfect romance,
The storybook ending.
It is the choice to stay
Even when staying hurts.
The courage to show up,
In all your mess and glory.

It is the moments when you are seen
And still, you remain.
The moments when you feel small,
But choose to love anyway.
Love is not a fairytale,
But it is the bravest thing you will ever do.

And even if love disappoints,
Even if it leaves,
You will never forget the strength
You found within it.

Reflection: I've come to understand that love is not about waiting for perfect conditions or easy moments. It's the choice to love even when it's hard, when it requires vulnerability, when it demands courage. And even if love disappoints, I can still hold the strength I gained from it.

The Space Between Us

We meet in moments,
In between the breaths,
The silence before the storm.
Love is not always the loud declaration,
But the quiet understanding
That passes between us like a glance.

In the space between the words
We share what we can never say.
In the space between our bodies
We touch the unspoken parts of our souls.
No distance is too great
When the heart knows the way home.

And yet, we build walls
Around the very thing that could set us free.
What if the most powerful thing we can do
Is simply to lean in,
Closer than ever before?

Reflection: I see now that love is not always about grand gestures. It's the quiet moments, the glances that say more than words ever could. We complicate love with distance and fear, forgetting that connection often lives in the spaces we create for each other, just by being present.

The Strength of Compassion

You don't need to be strong,
Not in the way the world defines it.
You don't need to bend yourself into shapes
That leaves you broken.
True strength is in your softness,
In your ability to feel deeply,
To empathize even when it hurts,
To stand tall in the face of your own vulnerability.

Compassion is not a weakness,
It is the muscle that keeps us human.
To care for another,
Even when your own wounds bleed,
Is the bravest thing you can do.

And when you meet another's pain
With the courage of your own heart,
You heal not only them,
But yourself as well.

Reflection: Compassion isn't about ignoring my own pain. It's about sitting with it and using it to understand others. I've learned that true strength isn't about how tough I can be, but about how deeply I can connect with the struggles of others, and still choose to love.

The Pain of Unspoken Truths

There are truths we hide,
Not because we don't know them,
But because they are too heavy
To carry in the open air.
We bury them deep,
Hoping they will stay quiet
For just a little while longer.

But truth is a seed,
And it will grow in silence,
Rooting itself into your bones
Until you can no longer ignore it.

The weight of unspoken truths
Can break you,
But it can also heal you.
The moment you choose to speak,
You step into the light of who you truly are.

Reflection: I realize now that the truths I bury inside only grow heavier with time. The silence I've chosen isn't a safe place; it's a prison. Speaking my truth may break me open, but it also has the power to heal. It's in the unveiling that I find freedom.

The Promise of Enough

You never needed to be perfect,
Only to be whole.
The pieces of you that are broken
Are the ones that teach you to heal,
To hold the cracks like treasures,
Worn but not shattered,
Weathered but still standing.
What if enough isn't something you earn,
But something you accept?
Acknowledge the spaces in your soul
Where love hasn't yet reached,
And give them time to fill.
Trust the process,
Even when the world tells you to rush.
In this moment, you are already enough.
And in the next, you will be more than you were.

Reflection:

In the rush of life, I've forgotten that I don't need to strive for perfection. I am enough as I am. I realize now that my broken pieces hold the potential for growth. If I give myself the space to breathe, I'll discover that healing doesn't demand speed it demands patience with myself.

The Smiles that Cut

They smile with faces I once knew,

But now they are strangers,

Their laughter hiding whispers of envy,

A quiet hunger to see me fall.

And I stand before them,

The same man who gave his body to them,

But I see how their smiles twist

How their admiration is laced with hatred,

How their eyes glint with the thrill of my destruction.

They want me to be great,

But only as long as I am small enough

For them to control.

I am both their savior and their enemy,

Their joy and their curse.

They cheer for my strength,

But the moment I show weakness,

I become their prey.

And they will tear me apart,

Piece by piece,

Until there is nothing left but the echoes

Of my love,

Still ringing in the silence they leave behind.

The Betrayal of a Kiss

They come to me,
With their words of loyalty,
With their promises of love,
But I know the truth they are all lies.
I see the glint in their eyes,
The way they pretend to care,
When all they want is to see me fall.
And in their kiss,
I taste the betrayal.

I thought they were my brothers,
My friends,
But they have already chosen their path,
And I am nothing more than a pawn in their game.
They will kiss me,
But it will not be a sign of love
It will be the mark of their treason.
And I will feel the sting of it,
The poison of their false devotion.
And I will still love them,
Even as they drive the knife deeper,
Because love knows no bounds,
Even when the world is full of knives.

The Prodigal

I left with pockets full of inheritance,
Eager to taste freedom on my tongue,
To shed the weight of my father's name,
To become someone entirely my own.

The world welcomed me with open arms,
Then closed its fist around my throat
When the money ran dry,
When my charm wore thin,
When my name meant nothing in strange lands.

I found myself kneeling in dirt,
Hands that once counted gold
Now scraping for scraps,
Mouth that once spoke with pride
Now silent with shame.

It wasn't hunger that drove me home
It was the memory of dignity,
The echo of love that never required earning.
I rehearsed apologies with each step,
Prepared to beg for the smallest corner.

But the road home is never as long
As the road away.
And there he stood,
Arms open like they never closed,
Eyes seeing me before I could see myself.

I thought I needed to be worthy of return,
But he showed me I was never unworthy of love.
The feast was not for my homecoming,
But for the death of the lie I believed
That I could ever fall beyond the reach of grace.

Reflection:

This poem draws from the parable of the Prodigal Son but reframes it as a deeply personal journey of self-forgiveness and rediscovery. It fits beautifully in *Love and Vulnerability* because it explores the courage to return to love, even after feeling unworthy. The father's unconditional love becomes a metaphor for the love we must learn to give ourselves.

Silence and the Unspoken

Introduction:

This section explores the power of what remains unsaid the weight of silence, the burden of secrets, and the pain of suppressed truths. These poems reveal how silence can be both a prison and a sanctuary, how the unspoken can shape us as profoundly as what is expressed. Through metaphors of locked rooms, hidden boxes, and quiet screams, these verses illuminate the struggle to find voice and the courage to break the silence that binds us.

"The Quiet Scream"

He never let the cracks show

not in his smile, not in the way he joked,

like a mask painted with borrowed light.

Every laugh was a mask,
every punchline a plea for someone
to see the scars that didn't bleed.

He learned early that tears were not for him,
that laughter was the only thing that could
distract from the bruises on his heart.

So, he turned every pain into a joke,
made every ache a punchline.

But inside, his chest was a battleground,
a place where the war never ended
and no one ever knew.

He didn't need to be fixed.

He needed to be seen.

But how do you tell someone
you're dying behind the mask
when they only ever see the performance?

Reflection:

This poem is about the pain of hiding behind humor. I've seen friends and myself use laughter as a shield, pretending everything is fine while breaking inside. The hardest part isn't the silence; it's realizing that the people around you may never understand the depth of your pain.

"The Box"

She was always told to keep it together,
to keep her mouth shut and her emotions tighter,
like a box with a latch that couldn't be opened.
But inside that box was everything
every word unsaid, every tear that never fell,
every thought left unspoken,
growing into a monster she could never control.
She smiled on the outside,
wore that mask like a second skin,
but the box was full of things she couldn't forget
the way she was touched when she wasn't ready,
the way her voice was stolen
before it had a chance to form.

No one asked her if she was okay,
no one noticed the weight she carried
they just told her to keep it together,
as if holding it all in was a virtue.
But the box was never meant to be locked.
And one day, it broke open,
and everything that had been held inside
came rushing out
a flood of words, of pain,
of stories she was never allowed to tell.

Reflection:

This poem speaks to the hidden traumas we carry. We're taught to suppress our emotions, to "keep it together," but those silences have a way of breaking free. The box can only stay closed for so long before it bursts open. Healing begins when we allow ourselves to confront what we've locked away.

Poem: "The Echo"

He was the kind of boy who always seemed
to be running from something,
though no one could ever tell exactly what.
He'd laugh loud, then fall silent,
disappear behind walls he'd built
out of jokes and bravado.
His eyes were always searching for something
for a way out,
for a way to prove he wasn't afraid.
But what no one knew was that the fear
had been with him from the start.

It was in the way his father never came home,
in the way his mother never looked up,
in the way his sisters whispered in the corners,
the family secrets folding in on themselves
like paper cranes with broken wings.
He had learned to live with the echoes
the empty rooms, the unspoken words,
the silence that stretched over him
like a second skin.

He never told anyone how loud those echoes were,
how the absence of love
was louder than anything he'd ever heard.
He filled the space with noise,
but the silence always found its way back.

Reflection:

I know someone like this someone who always seems to be running from something, but no one knows what it is. The trauma of an absent father, a distant mother, or a family too broken to heal these are the invisible scars that shape us. The hardest part isn't the pain it's the silence that comes with it, the space between words that nobody dares to address. The way we fill the silence with laughter, distractions, and noise, hoping that if we talk loud enough, the echoes won't catch up with us. But the echoes are always there, waiting to remind us of what we've lost.

Poem: "The Forgotten Room"

She never spoke about it
the room that no one ever opened,
the one with dust on the corners
and a lock that never seemed to fit.
Her eyes always glazed over
when the subject came up,
as if there were a part of her
she'd forgotten how to reach.

But I saw it once
the way her hands shook as she turned the key,
the way the door creaked open
like the sound of a truth long buried.
Inside, there were memories,
things she had packed away
and hidden from the world,
and from herself.
The photographs, the letters,
the things she thought she could forget.

We are taught to lock things away,
to pretend they don't matter,
but even the quietest rooms will whisper
if you listen close enough.
Her silence wasn't absence.
It was just a place she couldn't bear to visit,
but one she would never leave behind.

Reflection:

This poem speaks to the parts of us that we lock away memories, traumas, things we think we can forget. There's a room inside each of us where we store our secrets, our pain, and we close the door, thinking we've left it all behind. But the truth is, no matter how much we try to lock it up, those memories will always find their way back to us. I've seen friends struggle with things they can't talk about, with pasts they can't forget, and it makes me realize how much we carry with us without even knowing it. We think we're free, but we're never truly free from the rooms we've locked away.

Poem: "The Story He Never Told"

He was the kind of man who always had a story,
but none of them were ever about him.
He spoke of adventures, of distant lands,
of laughter and triumphs,
but I could see it in his eyes
the story he never told,
the one that made his hands tremble
when no one was watching.

It was in the way his shoulders slumped
when the night grew too quiet,
in the way his voice caught
when he spoke of his family.
There were things buried deep inside him,
things that even he wasn't sure how to name,
things that made him look in the mirror
and question who he was,
who he could have been,
if only he had been allowed to grow.

I never asked him what he was running from
maybe because I already knew.
He had been carrying it for so long
that it had become part of him.
The story was too painful to tell,
and so he kept it locked inside,
trading it for tales of laughter
and pretending that the silence didn't scream.

Reflection:

I think about how many of us live with untold stories, trapped in the space between our breaths and our words. We cover our scars with humor, with triumphs, with anything that distracts from the things we carry. I've seen friends like this people who wear the weight of their pasts, but never let anyone see it. They tell stories about everyone else, but never about themselves, because their own story is too painful to share. I understand that pain. There are things inside us that we think we can never speak aloud. But those untold stories are the ones that define us, whether we say them or not.

The Silent Scream

There is a voice in me that they cannot hear
A scream that rattles my bones,
A cry that no one knows exists.
I stand here,
Among them,
Smiling,
Nodding,
Pretending that I am part of the crowd.
But inside, I am unraveling.
Inside, I am tearing myself apart for them
For their peace,
For their joy,
For their salvation.
But they do not know how much it costs.
They cannot see the threads of my soul
Being pulled taut with each sacrifice I make.

I want to scream,
To shout,
To rage at the world that demands so much of me.
But I cannot
For in their eyes, I am nothing more than a sacrifice,
A tool,
A means to their end.
So I remain silent,
Even as the scream inside me grows louder,
Until it drowns out everything else,
Until I am no longer sure where I end
And they begin.

The Weight of the Unspoken

I walk among them,
And they cheer,
Yet their cheers are sharp,
Like broken glass beneath my feet
They don't see the blood,
The blood I've already spilled for them,
Spilled without asking,
Without hesitation.
I have offered them what they cannot take,
What they will never understand,
Not now, not ever.

They laugh and clap,
But their applause sounds empty,
Like a song with no melody,
A prayer with no voice.
I give them my every breath,
My heart,
And they worship what I am not,
Praising what they think they see.
They hold their hands out to me,
But those hands are not open
They are fists wrapped in confusion.

Do they even know I am dying?
Or is my death their victory?
I am nothing but a face to them,
A tool for their own desire,
A means to an end they never asked me about,
But somehow, I keep giving
Because that is what love does,
Even when no one asks for it.

Self-Sacrifice and Healing

Introduction:

These poems explore the delicate balance between giving to others and preserving the self. They speak to the paradox of love that both heals and breaks, the weight of expectations, and the journey toward wholeness. Through powerful imagery of empty vessels, thorned crowns, and healing hands, this section examines the cost of self-sacrifice and the path toward healing not just for others, but for oneself.

The Hands That Heal and Break

They come to me with hands outstretched,

But mine are scarred from holding too much,

Worn from carrying the weight of souls

Begging for what I cannot give.

What do they want from me?

Is it hope?

Is it a miracle?

Or is it simply to ease their suffering,

Even if that means destroying me in the process?

I lay my hands on them

And they think they are healed.

But the truth is,

I am the one who bleeds for them.

I give,

But they don't see the weight of it

The cost of my love.

They want the freedom that comes without the chains,

The peace that comes without the struggle,

And they take it

Even as they tear me apart in the process.

I heal them,

But in healing them,

I destroy myself

The paradox of love,

To give what can never be returned.

And when I am gone,

Will they remember what I gave?

Or will they simply carry on,

Blind to the scars I left in my wake?

The Empty Vessel

I have been emptied so many times,

Yet they come, filling me with their needs.

I give until there's nothing left,

Just the hollow echo of who I was.

But even then,

They do not stop.

They want more,

More than I can offer,

More than I have to give.

I am nothing but a vessel now,

A container for their wants,

For their dreams.

And I watch as they drink from me,

But never once do they see how dry I've become.

They take from me,

And I let them

Because love means giving even when there is nothing left to give.

But what happens when the vessel is empty?

What happens when the one who gave it all

Has nothing left to offer?

The Thorned Crown

They crown me with their love,
But their love is not a gentle thing
It is thorns,
Pressed into my flesh,
Piercing my skull,
Until the blood flows down my face.
They worship my sacrifice,
But do they understand it?
Do they see the pain in my eyes,
The tears I've shed alone,
The cost of this love they take without giving?

I wear the crown of their desire
A crown made not of gold,
But of broken dreams,
Of promises unkept,
Of hands that reach but never touch.
And they look at me with reverence,
But they do not know the weight of this crown,
How it presses against my brow,
How it cuts into my mind.
They ask for everything,
And I give,
But in giving, I become less than I was
Until I am nothing but a shadow of the man
They never truly knew.

The Empty Vessel

I have been emptied so many times,
But still they come
Filling me with their expectations,
Their desires,
Their needs.
I give and give,
Until there is nothing left but the hollow echo
Of who I once was.
But even then,
They do not stop.
They want more,
More than I can offer,
More than I have to give.

I am nothing but a vessel now,
A container for their wants,
For their dreams.
And I watch as they drink from me,
But never once do they see how dry I've become.
They take from me,
And I let them
Because love means giving even when there is nothing left to give.
But what happens when the vessel is empty?
What happens when the one who gave it all
Has nothing left to offer?

The Final Breath

And when it is over
 When the crowd has gone silent,
 When the weight of the world is finally lifted,
 What will they remember?
 Will they remember the love I gave?
 Will they remember the agony I bore for them?
 Or will they forget,
 As they always do,
 And move on,
 Leaving me behind in the dust?

I have given them everything
 My body,
 My heart,
 My soul.
 And still they do not see.
 But when I am gone,
 When the dust settles and the silence falls,
 I will rise again,
 Not as they wanted,
 But as the love they never knew they needed.
 And they will remember,
 In the quiet moments,
 In the spaces where their hearts still ache,
 That I loved them,
 Even when they never asked me to.

Reflection

These poems dive into the complex, often painful paradox of selfsacrifice and selflove. They explore the tension between giving everything to others whether through love, compassion, or duty and the exhaustion, the breaking of oneself in the process. There is a clear interplay between the desire to love unconditionally and the toll it takes when that love is unreciprocated or misunderstood. The speaker struggles to reconcile the divine call to love with the human cost of that love, and the painful truth that, sometimes, giving everything means losing yourself entirely. The journey through these poems is not just one of selfdestruction, but also a reflection on the struggle to remain human while carrying the weight of the world.

"The Art of Letting Go"

I have learned to let go of form,
to move like water
not fixed, not rigid,
but flowing in the shape of whatever it needs to be.
To be formless is to be free,
to shapeshift into whatever the moment demands.

I am not bound by expectation,
not trapped by tradition.
I am the wind that cannot be caught,
the shadow that cannot be held.
And in this formlessness,
I find my strength.
For when you assume nothing,
you become everything.

The Gift of Time

Time is both a blessing and a curse,
A river that carries us forward,
But also pulls us under.
We rush to meet its demands,
Forgetful of the moments we waste,
The minutes we cannot reclaim.

But time is also a gift
A reminder that every day
Is an opportunity to start anew.
The past is not where you live,
Nor is the future yours to hold.

The gift of time is the ability to choose,
To make each moment count,
To love without regret,
To give without expectation,
And to live with intention.

Reflection: Time is the most precious gift I have, yet I often forget its value. The past is behind me, and the future is uncertain. The only power I have is in how I use the present. Each moment is a new chance to choose how I show up in the world, and that's all I can control.

The Weight of Your Own Word

Words are more than just sounds,
They are the weight of your soul,
A reflection of your innermost truth,
Or the silence you refuse to acknowledge.
We carry our words like bricks,
Building walls around us,
Protecting our fragile hearts from the outside world.
But what if the walls we built
Are the ones that keep us in?
What if our silence is the chains
We choose to wear every day?

Speak only what uplifts,
What breaks chains and heals hearts.
Let your words be a bridge,
Not a barrier.

Reflection: Every word I speak has the power to either free or imprison me. I carry them like a sacred force, remembering that silence or speech both have consequences. In every moment, my words reflect my truth, and I have the power to choose what I say and what I leave unsaid.

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The Weight of Wings

They told me I was born to fly,
But they never warned me about the weight of wings.
How they stretch wide,
Casting shadows over the ground I long to touch.
How they ache with the memory of every fall,
Every time I leapt and the sky refused to catch me.

I have carried these wings like a burden,
Their feathers heavy with the dust of dreams deferred.
I have tried to fold them,
To hide them beneath the armor of my doubt,
But they always unfurl,
Reaching for a freedom I am too afraid to claim.

What they don't tell you about flying
Is that it's not the wind that lifts you
It's the courage to leap,
To trust the air to hold you,
Even when the ground feels safer.

And so, I leap again,
Not because I am fearless,
But because I am tired of the weight.
Because I have learned that the only way
To lighten the burden of wings
Is to use them.

Reflection:

This poem speaks to the tension between fear and freedom, the struggle to embrace our potential despite the weight of past failures. It reminds me that courage isn't the absence of fear it's the decision to leap anyway. The wings we carry may feel heavy, but they are also the tools that will set us free.

Home and Belonging

Introduction:

What does it mean to belong? Where do we find home? This section explores the search for a place physical or spiritual where one feels truly accepted. These poems journey through the landscapes of longing, the places we've never been but somehow recognize, and the possibility that home might not be a destination but a feeling we carry within. They speak to the universal human desire to find where we truly belong.

Where the Wind Knows My Name"

I've walked through rooms that don't echo
 Like I'm a shadow, cast too far from the light.
 My hands have touched the walls,
 But they've never felt like mine.
 I've slept in beds made of strangers' sheets,
 Hoping the fabric would whisper where I belong.
 My heart beats like a traveler's compass
 Pointing in every direction,
 But never landing.
 The world tells me I am "lost,"
 But I don't feel that way.
 I feel like I am simply
 Moving through rooms,
 Moving through time,
 Moving toward the scent of something familiar
 I've never known.
 Maybe home isn't a place,
 Maybe it's the sound of my name
 Carried by the wind,
 Where I don't have to ask if I'm wanted
 Because the air already knows.
 It's waiting to wrap me in its arms,
 And say, "You are mine."

"The Places We Are Not"

Sometimes I dream of places I've never been,
And they feel more like home than the places I've known.
A street lit by lanterns where I never feel alone,
A kitchen where the smell of bread rises
And settles over me like warmth from a mother's touch.
But those places are only shadows in my mind,
The ones that whisper in the quiet of the night.
In the morning, they fade like dew on grass,
Leaving only the cold of reality behind.
I search for them in crowded cities,
Where noise drowns the quiet kind of peace I'm chasing.
I search for them in faces that never see me
And places that don't know my story.
It's not the walls or roads that make a home
It's the knowing.
The knowing that when you arrive,
You're not a visitor,
Not a stranger passing through,
But someone whose absence has been felt,
Whose return is welcomed with open arms.
And until then, I'll keep chasing
The places that hold me even when I'm not there,
The ones that make me feel like I've always belonged.
Even when I'm still finding my way.

"What If Home Was Inside Us All Along?"

I've been chasing maps,
Seeking the edges of the earth,
Thinking that home is out there somewhere,
Just beyond the horizon.
But every road I've traveled
Leads back to the mirror,
Where I see myself
The same lost soul,
Hoping to find something that would make me whole.
What if home isn't a city?
What if it isn't a house with four walls?
What if it's just the silence between thoughts,
The quiet within me,
The space where I don't need to prove anything?
I close my eyes and feel the air of the world,
The way it moves through me,
Like I'm both the wind and the place it flows.
Maybe home isn't the place I want to arrive at,
But the place I already am.
Maybe home is the acceptance
That I don't need to run anymore.
I open my eyes and realize
That I have been home all along.
It was never out there.
It was always inside.

Reflection

I've been searching for a place where I fit, where I don't have to carve out space for myself because it's already there, waiting. I feel like home is somewhere just outside of reach, somewhere not defined by walls but by the way it feels when the world stops asking me to prove I belong. Maybe that's what it's all about the moment the universe stops questioning you and just accepts you, like the wind knows your name before you do.

"The Door to the Future"

I walked through the door of now,
knowing it would never look the same again.
The past, with all its weight,
clung to my ankles like sand,
but I kicked it off,
one step at a time.

I do not need to know what lies ahead
to walk into it with open eyes.
The future has no face
until I give it one.
And so, I take the next step,
not to outrun fear,
but to embrace it as a companion
along the road of becoming.

Reflection:

These poems, rooted in the themes of power, truth, and personal evolution, mirror the delicate balance between silence and action, vulnerability and strength. In each piece, I explore the tension between holding space and asserting dominance, choosing when to reveal and when to conceal. The journey within these verses reflects the intricacies of navigating both internal and external worlds recognizing the power of words, the influence of silence, and the beauty in the pause before a decision is made. The path is not always clear, nor is it linear, but in the reflection of each poem, I find the truth that we shape our future through the choices we make today, the restraint we practice, and the awareness we cultivate. Power lies not in domination, but in the wisdom to know when to speak and when to be still.

Stories of Pain and Redemption

Introduction:

This final section delves into the darker landscapes of the human experience pain, trauma, violence, and the possibility of redemption. Through metaphor and vivid imagery, these poems explore the shadows within and around us, the weight of consequence, and the complex journey toward healing. They remind us that even in our darkest moments, there remains the possibility of light, of understanding, and of transformation.

The Silence Between Breaths

The Mind of a Killer

The air thickens before the strike,
A thousand thoughts swim like blood in my veins,
Each breath is a drum, pounding,
Not for mercy, but for meaning.
I wear silence like a crown,

A stillness born of pain.

The heartbeat of my past echoes in my chest,

A reminder of the lives I've touched and lost.

But am I the sculptor, or the tool?
Do I shape them, or do they shape me?
I cut away the world's noise,
Leaving only the sharp edge of truth.
In their eyes, I see reflections,
Whispers of my own fractures,
In their scream, I hear the voice of my own undoing.
Every movement is deliberate,
A story told with the precision of a blade.
Every life, a page turned,
Every death, a sentence written.

Yet, I am not the author.
The book is already written,
Bound in the blood of a thousand forgotten souls.
They are the ones who left their mark on me,
Who whispered their secrets as they bled.
I am the keeper of stories
I do not choose the ending.

The moment of impact is where truth resides,
For in death, all things are revealed.
The only question remains
Do I remember their names?

The Hands of Time*The Clock Ticks on the Battlefield of Memory*

I remember every hand I've touched,
Not in love, but in the grip of fate.
The same hands that pull the trigger
Once cradled innocence,
But innocence is fragile,
A butterfly crushed by the weight of inevitability.
Time is a thief that robs me of my youth,
But I never was a child, was I?
Born in shadow,
Raised in the deafening hum of war,
Each tick of the clock a call to arms.

I've learned to ignore the hands that point at me.
Their accusations don't sting,
Because I know their story
It's the same one I carry.

The Veil of Shadows*The Faces in the Dark*

There are faces that haunt me,
Not in my dreams, but in the waking world.
Faces I cannot place,
Yet I know their eyes,
Their blood, their fears.
They are the ones I've swallowed whole,
Their spirits twisting inside me
Like vines around my soul.
I wear their faces like a mask,
Shadows whispering their truths to me.
They show me what I've done,
And ask if I can forgive myself.

They know I am nothing but a reflection
Of a world too cold to care.
They see the truth
I am only a ghost,
Haunting my own heart.

The River of Red*The Weight of Consequence*

A river flows through my veins,
Carrying the red of those I've taken,
A current of guilt and power,
Churning beneath my skin.
The water is thick,
It clings to me,
It stains me,
But it is mine
Mine to drink,
Mine to drown in. I thought it would cleanse me.
I thought I could wash away
The stains of my past.
But the more I try to cleanse,
The more it pulls me under.
The river does not forgive.
It carves its way forward,
Dragging everything in its path.
And I am the river,
And I am the stone sinking at its bottom.

The Burial Ground of Broken Souls

The Final Rest

In the soil, they sleep
 The ones whose names have never been spoken,
 Whose lives were taken before they could begin.
 I remember each of them,
 Not as victims, but as echoes.
 For the ground does not forgive
 It holds us in a chokehold,
 In its silence,
 Until we are forgotten. But I cannot forget.
 Each grave is a mirror,
 Reflecting the damage I've done,
 The lives I've torn from the earth,
 And buried beneath the weight of my guilt.
 I walk the cemetery,
 Not in sorrow,
 But in acceptance.
 For I am not the keeper of the dead
 I am one of them,
 Only waiting for the day
 I am buried too.

Black Boy in a Suit

I came dressed for survival, not acceptance.

They say I look like a man now.
 That the suit makes me safe.
 That my cuffs speak fluency,
 and my collar says "Yes, sir."

But they never ask
 what it cost to button this shirt—
 how many pieces of me were stitched into the lining,
 how much blood I had to iron out of my seams.

This suit is not fabric.
 It is armor disguised as elegance.
 It is the funeral garment for the boy they buried
 so the man could be born clean.

They cheer when I smile through clenched teeth,
 applaud my diction,
 nod at my posture—
 but they don't see the war I'm hiding in my chest.

I walk into boardrooms like I walked into classrooms—
 half threat, half miracle,
 trying not to flinch when I hear my own voice
 echo back too polished, too distant,
 too not-me.

Every compliment is a cage.
"You're so articulate."
"You don't even sound Black."
"You're not like the others."

This tie is a noose with a Gucci label.
 These shoes were made to run from myself.

They call it progress.
 I call it performance.

Because what they really love
 is the way I've made myself small enough
 to fit their comfort.
 The way I wear their standards like shackles
 and call it success.

But listen—
 underneath this suit,
 I still bleed in native tongues.
 My rage still walks barefoot on hot concrete.
 My laughter still echoes through barbershops and basements.
 The boy they tried to dress in their image
 still lives.

The Truth We Bury

They told us the truth was a monument,
 Carved in stone, unshakable, eternal.
 But I have walked among the ruins,
 And I have seen the cracks.

They told us the truth was a light,
 Blinding and pure,
 But I have stood in its glare,
 And found shadows hiding behind it.

They told us the truth was a weapon,
 Sharp enough to cut through lies,
 But I have held it in my hands,
 And felt it slice through me instead.

This generation was born into a world of mirrors,
 Where every reflection is distorted,
 Where every voice is an echo of another,
 And the truth is buried beneath the noise.

But listen
 The truth is not in the monuments,
 Not in the light,
 Not in the weapon.
 The truth is in the quiet places,
 The spaces between breaths,
 The moments when the world stops screaming
 And you can finally hear your own heart.

The truth is not what they give you,
 It is what you find when everything else is stripped away.
 It is the courage to ask the questions
 They told you not to ask.
 It is the strength to stand in the silence
 And face what you've been running from.

The truth is not a thing to be held,
 It is a thing to be lived.
 It is the way you choose to love
 When hate is easier.
 It is the way you choose to hope
 When despair feels safer.
 It is the way you choose to rise
 When the world tells you to kneel.

We are the generation of seekers,
 Of builders,
 Of breakers.
 We will not find the truth in their monuments,
 But in the rubble we sift through,
 In the stories we tell,
 In the lives we live.

The truth is not a destination.
 It is the journey we take together,
 The light we carry in the dark,
 The fire we pass from hand to hand
 Until the lies burn away
 And only the truth remains.

Reflection:

This poem is a call to a generation searching for meaning in a world of contradictions. It reminds us that

truth is not something handed down it is something we must uncover for ourselves. It is not static or simple, but alive, dynamic, and deeply personal. In a time of overwhelming noise, this poem invites us to listen, to question, and to live with integrity. It is a reminder that the truth is not found in the world's monuments, but in the quiet courage of our own hearts.

Epilogue: The Boy Becomes

I have written myself into existence,
letter by letter, line by line,
leaving pieces of my soul between these pages
unfolding, unbecoming, becoming.

I have learned that silence can be survival,
but so can the sound of my own voice.
That I am more than the echoes of my ancestors' sorrow,
more than the fears the world projected onto me.

I have seen my reflection splinter in the weight of expectation,
but I have also seen it rise, whole,
no longer a question, no longer an apology
but a statement, a presence, a name that refuses to be forgotten.

I do not write for permission.
I do not exist for approval.
I am the dream and the dreamer,
the poem and the poet,
the truth they tried to rewrite,
still standing, still speaking.

And if the world asks who I am,
let these words be my answer:
I am here. I am whole. I am free.

The End

About the Author

Kiminou is a poet and storyteller whose work explores the depths of Black identity, resilience, and emotional truth. With a distinct voice that blends lyrical beauty with raw honesty, Kiminou crafts narratives that challenge, heal, and inspire. Their writing is deeply rooted in cultural history, personal experience, and the unspoken stories of the Black community.

Black Boy Poems is a reflection of that commitment an evocative collection that captures the complexities of Black boyhood, manhood, and the spaces in between. Through powerful imagery and poignant storytelling, Kiminou sheds light on the struggles, triumphs, and enduring strength found within Black life.

Their work serves as both a mirror and a call to action, encouraging readers to embrace their truths and engage with the world in deeper, more meaningful ways.

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